



A Distro Hopper's Final Destination?

SimplyMEPIS, just like PCLinuxOS, once had an edge over the mainstream distros, thanks to its being geared towards desktop and ease-of-use factors. Does it still hold that edge? We take a look at the latest version 8 and find out.

If you are like me, choosing the 'Right One' is always difficult. The tummy bulge of applications is despised at first sight. Beautiful looks get a second and third greedy gaze. Having the 'right asset' among applications for daily work is just too good to walk away from. A few distros like LinuxMint, DreamLinux and PCLinuxOS do have these qualities, but it is SimplyMEPIS 8 that takes the crown for this review.

It was on February 24, 2009, that SimplyMEPIS 8 was finally out after a long wait of more than a year. Built on Debian 5.0 'Lenny', you can certainly expect SimplyMEPIS 8 to be rock solid on the stability front. In fact, this is the first release from Warren Woodford, founder and lead developer of MEPIS Linux, along with the MEPISlovers community, which makes this version 8 very special. It has community inputs to the desktop theme and user manual, an auto-running intro on the CD, and some updates to the 'assistants'.

Where to get it

SimplyMEPIS8 is a live/install CD available for 32-bit and 64-bit PCs. Well, the good news is that this month's *LFY* has included the 32-bit ISO in the accompanying DVD. Select the relevant image from *distros_iso* directory of the DVD and burn it into a blank CD.

A quick look at the features

- KDE 3.5.10
- Linux 2.6.27-1-mepis-smp
- OpenOffice.org 3.0
- Firefox 3.0.6
- Guarddog firewall configuration utility
- BIND 0.9.6 and IPv6, enabled out-of-the-box
- Virtualisation is easily supported by downloading KVM 84 and libvirt 0.6.0 from the MEPIS 8.0 package pool
- An excellent set of MEPIS Tools similar to Mandriva Control Center (MCC) or openSUSE Yast

First impressions

Booting into the KDE desktop took about a minute and a half. The password for the root